



A TURNING POINT IN THE HISTORY OF NATIONS

THE PEACE OF WESTPHALIA (1648)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

International law

BEFORE

1555 The Peace of Augsburg allows each prince within the Holy Roman Empire to decree his state's religion.

1568 The 17 provinces of the Low Countries rebel against Philip II of Spain, beginning the Eighty Years' War.

1618 The Thirty Years' War erupts between Protestant and Catholic states within the Holy Roman Empire.

AFTER

1919 The Treaty of Versailles officially ends World War I and creates many new nation-states from the territory of former empires, including Habsburg Austria-Hungary.

1920 The League of Nations (the precursor of the United Nations, or UN) is established.

By the mid-17th century, the Holy Roman Empire (made up of territories in central and western Europe and at this time ruled by the Habsburg dynasty) had been plagued by conflict for decades, resulting in famine and instability throughout the region.

The Thirty Years' War (1618–1648) began when Holy Roman Emperor Ferdinand II attempted to enforce

religious uniformity on the empire by suppressing Protestantism and promoting Catholicism. Many Protestant states rebelled, forming the Protestant Union and setting up a rival emperor, Frederick V.

This religious war morphed into a conflict of dynastic ambitions, which pitted the Habsburgs of the Holy Roman Empire against ascendant Bourbon France and the growing military might of Sweden. Meanwhile the Eighty Years' War (1568–1648) between Spain (also ruled by the Habsburgs) and the provinces of the Low Countries, which sought independence,

At the Battle of Lützen in Saxony in 1632, the Protestant king of Sweden, Gustavus II Adolphus, was killed fighting the forces of Ferdinand II. Eight million people died in the Thirty Years' War.

